

EUDR Due Diligence Starter

A structured internal file per lot with scope decisions, supplier data, coordinate references, legality exhibits, risk notes, and statement tracking.

Galaxy Forge Implementation Kit | Version 1.0 | September 2026

Companion files: Excel workbook, editable Word templates, README.

EUDR Due Diligence Starter Guide. Slug `eudr_due_diligence_starter`. Price \$69. Version 1.0. This guide helps importers, first-placers, and small and medium traders who place coffee, cocoa, soy, palm products, rubber, or wood products on the European Union market to organize practical internal work for Regulation on deforestation-free products. It explains what the rule asks operators to do, how to set up simple registers and logs, how to request plot geolocation and legality evidence from suppliers, how to prepare an internal file that supports a Due Diligence Statement, and how to track deadlines of 30 December 2026 for large and medium enterprises and 30 June 2027 for micro and small enterprises. This guide is general information and is not legal advice. Scope and classifications may evolve, so re-verify with official sources and counsel before acting. It does not promise any regulatory outcome.

How to use this kit. The kit contains this guide, a workbook with five sheets, and three document templates. Start with Section 2 to confirm whether your goods fall inside the commodity scope. Then open the workbook sheet called Scope Checker and record each product, customs code, and reason for your scope decision. Next open the Supplier Register and list every direct supplier, the commodity supplied, and the contact responsible for documents. Then use the DDS Preparation Log to track each planned placement lot, the evidence collected, and the checks performed. Use the Deadline Calendar to map internal milestones back from 30 December 2026 or 30 June 2027. Send the Supplier Data Request Letter early, because plot data and legality documents often take weeks to arrive. Finish each lot with a Gap Memo that records what is still missing and who owns the next step.

Background in plain language. The European Union adopted a regulation that prohibits placing certain commodities on the Union market, or exporting them from it, unless three conditions are met. First, the goods must be deforestation-free under the definition and cut-off date stated in the official text. Second, they must have been produced in accordance with the relevant legislation of the country of production. Third, they must be covered by a Due Diligence Statement submitted by the operator before placement. Operators and traders have distinct duties, with operators carrying the full due diligence duty and traders downstream carrying record-keeping and traceability duties that differ by enterprise size. Because official guidance, commodity lists, country classifications, and information-system

procedures have been updated over time, always consult the current official text and official guidance before you rely on any summary, including this one.

Commodities and products in scope. The regulation covers cattle, cocoa, coffee, oil palm, rubber, soya, and wood, plus listed derived products identified by customs nomenclature in the official annex. Relevant derived products include items such as chocolate preparations, coffee preparations, palm oil fractions, soy flour and meal, natural rubber articles, and a defined set of wood and paper articles, each tied to specific codes. Your task is not to memorize the annex but to run a repeatable check for every Stock Keeping Unit you handle. Record the commercial name, the customs code you actually declare, the commodity family it maps to, and whether you treat it as in scope, out of scope, or uncertain pending counsel review. Keep the evidence for out-of-scope decisions too, because a later assortment change or code correction can move a product back into scope.

Dated scope update, September 2026. Delegated Regulation (EU) 2026/2102, in force since 18 September 2026, amended the product annex: bovine hides, skins and leather products, retreaded tyres, soya beans for sowing, and certain rubber articles were removed from scope, while soluble coffee, certain palm oil derivatives, and frozen bovine tongues were added with application from 30 December 2027. Do not rely on any static product list, including any list inside this kit, as current. Re-check your Stock Keeping Units against the current official annex before every consequential scope decision, and record the date and source of each check in the Scope Checker sheet.

Who is an operator and who is a trader. An operator is a person or company that first places a relevant product on the Union market or exports it. A trader is a person further down the supply chain who makes the product available. If you import coffee bags from outside the Union and sell them inside the Union, you act as an operator for that lot even if you are a small company. If you buy that same coffee inside the Union from an importer and resell it, you generally act as a trader. Distributors, roasters, private-label sellers, and fulfilment arrangements need to map their role per lot, not per company, because the same company can be an operator for imported lots and a trader for domestic purchases. Record the role decision in the DDS Preparation Log for every lot so the file shows consistent reasoning.

The three pillars of due diligence. Pillar one is information collection. You must gather the product description, quantity, country of production and sub-national detail where required, plot geolocation coordinates, dates or time ranges of production, supplier identity and contact details, and documents supporting legality. Pillar two is risk assessment. You must assess the risk that the lot is linked to deforestation or to non-compliance with relevant local law, considering factors such as origin area risk, supply-chain complexity, mixing and blending points, documentation gaps, and any substantiated concerns raised by third parties. Pillar three is risk mitigation. Where risk is more than negligible, you must take proportionate steps such as seeking additional evidence, commissioning independent checks, changing suppliers or plots, or deciding not to place the lot. Document each step even when the conclusion is that risk is negligible.

Geolocation and the deforestation-free condition. For each lot you must obtain the geographic coordinates of the plots where the commodity was produced. Depending on plot size and the official rules, this means either single points or polygons with a defined number of vertices. For bulk commodities such as soy or coffee assembled from many smallholders, this requirement is operationally demanding, because every contributing plot should be identified and the chain must preserve the link between the lot and those plots. Ask suppliers early whether they can provide polygon

files, point lists, harvest dates, farm identifiers, and a written statement of the method used to collect the coordinates. Store the raw files, note the coordinate reference system, record the number of plots and points, and log any plots you could not verify. Never invent coordinates and never copy coordinates from one lot to another.

Legality in the country of production. The regulation requires that production complied with relevant legislation of the country of production, which can cover land-use rights, environmental protection, forest management, third-party rights, labor rights, human rights protected under international law, free prior and informed consent where applicable, and tax, anti-corruption, trade, and customs rules. In practice you evidence this with permits, land titles or use contracts, harvest authorizations, environmental licences, labor and tax records, and chain-of-custody certificates where available. Different commodities and origins rely on different document sets, so agree the expected document list per supplier in writing, record what was received and its date and issuer, and note missing items in the Gap Memo. Where documents are in a local language, keep the original plus a working translation and record who prepared the translation and when.

The Due Diligence Statement. Before placing goods, the operator submits a Due Diligence Statement through the official information system, referencing the lot, the product description and quantity, the country of production, the geolocation data, and a statement that due diligence was carried out and that risk was found to be negligible. The system returns a reference number that travels with the goods and is quoted in customs and customer documentation. Your internal DDS Preparation Log mirrors this structure so that nothing is submitted before the file is complete. Assign one owner per statement, record the internal review date, the reviewer name and function, the system submission date, and the reference number once issued. Keep superseded drafts to show the review history, and never submit a statement for a lot with open gaps unless counsel has reviewed the specific facts.

Deadlines and transition planning. Application dates differ by enterprise size. Large and medium enterprises must apply the duties from 30 December 2026. Micro and small enterprises have a later application date of 30 June 2027. These dates determine when you must have registers, logs, supplier data flows, and statement procedures working in daily operation, not when you should start preparing. Work backward from your applicable date. Allow time for supplier outreach, at least one full pilot lot with real coordinates and documents, staff training, and an internal file review. If you sell across seasons, map harvest calendars against your placement calendar so that lots harvested near the cut-off date receive extra scrutiny. The Deadline Calendar sheet in the workbook gives you a week-by-week structure for this backward plan with owners and status fields.

Regulatory change caveat. Read this section carefully. Commodity lists, product codes, country classifications, information-system fields, guidance documents, and enforcement practice may evolve after this guide was written. Classification decisions and benchmark outcomes published on one date can change on a later date. Do not treat any summary, checklist, or illustrative example in this kit as a substitute for the current official legal text and current official guidance. Before you finalize a scope decision, a supplier approval, a risk conclusion, or a Due Diligence Statement, re-verify the applicable rules with official sources and with qualified counsel in your jurisdiction. This kit does not provide legal advice and does not promise any regulatory outcome. Where this guide states a deadline or a procedural step, confirm it against the current official source at the time you act.

Method overview in five phases. Phase 1 Confirm Scope takes one to two weeks and produces a completed Scope Checker for every Stock Keeping Unit. Phase 2 Map Supply Chain takes two to four

weeks and produces a Supplier Register with every direct supplier, intermediary, and known collection point. Phase 3 Collect Evidence takes four to eight weeks and produces plot files, legality documents, and a completed data-request trail per supplier. Phase 4 Assess and Mitigate takes one to three weeks per lot and produces a risk assessment note and mitigation record. Phase 5 File and Archive produces the submitted Due Diligence Statement reference and a closed lot file with a Gap Memo for residual items. Small teams can run phases 2 and 3 in parallel across suppliers, but never skip the written Gap Memo, because it is the document that proves you saw the gaps and assigned them.

Workflow 1 commodity scope checker. Step 1 list every product you place or plan to place, including samples and seasonal items. Step 2 enter the customs code from your actual declaration, not from a catalog. Step 3 map each code to one of the seven commodity families or mark it as no mapping found. Step 4 record in-scope, out-of-scope, or uncertain, with a short reason citing the annex entry or the counsel note you relied on. Step 5 have a second person review uncertain items. Step 6 lock the sheet with a review date and reviewer initials function, and schedule re-verification each quarter or whenever you add a product, change a supplier, or see a notice about code or classification updates. Illustrative example, labeled illustrative: a trader lists three items, roasted coffee under one code mapped to coffee, a cocoa preparation mapped to cocoa, and a wooden gift box mapped to wood, marking two as in scope and one as uncertain pending counsel review of the exact code.

Workflow 2 supplier register. Step 1 create one row per direct supplier and per supply site where a supplier operates multiple mills or collection stations. Step 2 record legal name, country, address, contact person function, email, and phone. Step 3 record commodity, annual volume band, and whether the supplier provides farm-level plots or only aggregated collection data. Step 4 attach the signed data-request letter date and the agreed return date. Step 5 track document receipts with dates. Step 6 score responsiveness on a simple scale of complete, partial, or non-responsive, and record escalation actions. Step 7 review quarterly and suspend new orders from persistently non-responsive sources until gaps close. Illustrative example, labeled illustrative: a soy importer registers two crush plants, one providing polygon files within ten days and one providing only district names, so the second is marked partial with a follow-up owner and date.

Workflow 3 DDS preparation log. Create one row per placement lot. Enter lot identifier, product, quantity with unit, harvest period, country and sub-national origin, number of plots, coordinate file reference, legality document references, supplier name, role determination of operator or trader, risk assessment date, mitigation actions if any, reviewer, internal approval date, submission date, and system reference number. Link each cell to the underlying file name so an auditor can move from the log to the evidence in seconds. Freeze the row once submitted, and record amendments as new rows referencing the original, never by overwriting history. Illustrative example, labeled illustrative: a coffee lot of 500 bags links to a point list of 42 plots, three legality permits, a risk note dated two weeks before shipment, and a system reference recorded on submission day.

Workflow 4 deadline calendar. Enter your enterprise size and applicable date, either 30 December 2026 or 30 June 2027. Then create backward milestones: supplier letters sent, pilot lot selected, coordinates received, legality pack received, risk assessment signed, staff training completed, information-system access tested, first statement submitted, and file archive verified. Assign an owner and a due date to each milestone and update status weekly as not started, in progress, blocked, or done. Add harvest-season markers so that lots sourced right after harvest receive priority for coordinate collection while farm access is easiest. Review the calendar in a short weekly stand-up and

move blocked items to the Gap Memo the same day. Illustrative example, labeled illustrative: a medium roaster sets the pilot lot eight weeks before its first planned placement and reserves two weeks for rework after internal review.

Workflow 5 supplier data request letter. Send a formal written request for every in-scope supplier. The template in this kit covers product and lot identification, the exact coordinate format you accept, the legality document list, the return deadline, the contact for questions, data-protection handling, and a declaration of accuracy to be signed by the supplier. Personalize the commodity section, because a cattle supplier and a wood supplier provide different evidence. Keep proof of sending and any read receipts. Log the response date in the Supplier Register. If the supplier delegates to a sub-supplier or cooperative, ask for the delegation in writing and extend the same request down the chain. Illustrative example, labeled illustrative: a cocoa buyer sends the letter six weeks before shipment, receives partial points in two weeks, and issues a second request specifically for the missing polygons and harvest dates.

Workflow 6 gap memo. Close every lot with a one-page memo that lists what was complete, what was missing, what compensating evidence was used, what risk conclusion was reached, who approved it, and what follow-up remains. A good gap memo is short, dated, and signed by function, not by personal reputation. It should allow a new staff member to understand the lot status in five minutes. File the memo with the lot, copy open actions into the next lot for the same supplier, and review repeat gaps quarterly to decide whether to support the supplier with training or to source elsewhere. Illustrative example, labeled illustrative: a rubber lot memo records that two of thirty plots lacked polygons, that the supplier committed replacements by a fixed date, and that placement proceeded only after counsel reviewed the specific facts and the file.

Segregation, mixing, and mass balance discipline. Many supply chains mix compliant and non-compliant volumes at mills, silos, or warehouses. Unless the official rules for your product and supply-chain model allow a specific mass-balance or segregation approach with documented controls, assume that mixing breaks traceability and prevents a clean statement for the mixed lot. Ask each supplier to describe in writing whether lots are kept identity-preserved, segregated, or mixed, and at which nodes mixing can occur. Record storage and transport nodes in the Supplier Register notes field. Where mixing cannot be excluded, either change the sourcing setup or seek counsel advice before proceeding. Do not average coordinates across farms and do not reuse one farm file for a different harvest period.

Record keeping and file structure. Keep one folder per lot with subfolders for scope evidence, supplier correspondence, coordinate files, legality documents, risk notes, the submitted statement, and the gap memo. Use consistent file names that include lot identifier and date. Retain records for at least the period required by the official text, and longer if your customer contracts or counsel advise it. Control access so that commercial staff can read status fields but only trained reviewers can edit risk conclusions. Back up coordinate files separately, because they are the hardest to replace. Log every disclosure of the file to customers or authorities with date and recipient function. A tidy file shortens audits and reduces repeated supplier requests.

Roles, training, and internal controls. Assign four functions even in a small team, combining roles only in writing: a scope owner who maintains the Scope Checker, a supplier owner who sends letters and chases responses, an evidence reviewer who checks coordinates and documents, and a statement approver who authorizes submission. Train all four on the regulatory-change caveat, on how to read a

polygon file, on common legality documents per origin, and on when to escalate to counsel. Keep a one-page training log with dates and attendees by function. Review access to the official information system quarterly and remove leavers promptly. Rotate the reviewer for high-volume lots so that one person does not approve their own sourcing decisions without a second pair of eyes.

Checklist A scope confirmation. One, every Stock Keeping Unit listed. Two, customs code verified against declarations. Three, commodity family mapped or marked no mapping. Four, scope decision recorded with reason. Five, uncertain items flagged for counsel. Six, second review completed. Seven, review date and function recorded. Eight, re-verification scheduled. Nine, out-of-scope evidence retained. Ten, assortment-change trigger defined. Checklist B supplier onboarding. One, legal identity verified. Two, sites and collection points listed. Three, commodity and volume band recorded. Four, data-request letter sent and logged. Five, coordinate capability confirmed. Six, legality list agreed. Seven, responsiveness tracked. Eight, escalation path defined. Nine, quarterly review scheduled. Ten, suspension criteria documented.

Checklist C lot evidence. One, lot identifier assigned. Two, quantity and unit recorded. Three, harvest period recorded. Four, country and sub-national origin recorded. Five, plot files received and counted. Six, coordinate format and reference system noted. Seven, legality documents received and dated. Eight, translations filed where needed. Nine, chain-of-custody nodes described. Ten, risk assessment signed. Eleven, mitigation actions recorded or marked not applicable with reason. Twelve, reviewer and approver recorded. Thirteen, statement reference recorded. Fourteen, gap memo filed. Checklist D submission readiness. One, all mandatory system fields mapped. Two, coordinate files validated for completeness. Three, quantity units match declarations. Four, supplier identity matches register. Five, risk conclusion documented. Six, open gaps reviewed by counsel where needed. Seven, approver sign-off dated. Eight, archive location recorded.

Illustrative examples, all labeled illustrative. Example 1, illustrative: a coffee importer with two origins runs the Scope Checker, confirms both roasted and soluble lines map to coffee, marks merchandise such as mugs as out of scope with reasons, and sends data-request letters eight weeks before the first lot. Example 2, illustrative: a cocoa trader discovers that one supplier can only provide district names, so the file records partial status, the gap memo assigns a polygons-due date, and the trader arranges a site visit through a local agent to collect points. Example 3, illustrative: a soy buyer finds that a silo mixes multiple farms without segregation, so the buyer either shifts to an identity-preserved stream or seeks counsel advice before any statement. Example 4, illustrative: a wood importer aligns customs codes with the annex, separates solid-wood furniture from excluded seating components after counsel review, and keeps both decisions on file.

More illustrative examples, all labeled illustrative. Example 5, illustrative: a palm distributor acting as a trader records upstream statement references per lot and keeps supplier declarations that upstream due diligence was performed, without duplicating the operator file. Example 6, illustrative: a rubber goods seller maps three finished articles to rubber, collects points for smallholder plots via a cooperative, and logs translation of land-use certificates by function and date. Example 7, illustrative: a micro enterprise with the 30 June 2027 date uses the extra months to run two pilot lots, train one evidence reviewer, and test information-system access before live shipments. Example 8, illustrative: a medium furniture maker sets a rule that no lot is submitted with more than a defined small number of missing plots unless counsel has reviewed the exact facts, and writes that rule into its procedure.

Frequently asked questions. One, does this kit make my goods compliant. No. It organizes evidence and process. Only the facts of the lot, assessed against current official rules, determine the outcome, and counsel should review difficult cases. Two, can I reuse one farm file for repeated lots. No, unless the harvest period, plots, and chain match the new lot and you document the link. Three, what if my supplier will not share polygons. Record the refusal, escalate, seek alternative evidence or suppliers, and ask counsel whether any placement is supportable on the facts. Four, do samples need statements. Assess every placement including samples under the same scope logic and record the decision. Five, how do I handle blended lots. Treat blending as a traceability risk, document nodes, and do not submit unless the facts support it.

More frequently asked questions. Six, what units should I use. Use the units your declaration and the information system require, and keep them consistent across the log, the statement, and customs papers. Seven, how long should I keep files. At least as long as the official text requires, and longer if contracts or counsel advise. Eight, who can submit the statement. Only an authorized person with tested system access, after documented internal approval. Nine, what if country classifications change. Re-verify scope and risk conclusions against the current official source and update open lots before submission. Ten, can traders ignore geolocation. No. Traders must keep traceability information and upstream references as the rules require for their role; record what you hold per lot. Eleven, what if documents are in another language. Keep originals plus working translations with preparer function and date.

Further frequently asked questions. Twelve, should I audit every farm. Proportionate checks depend on risk. High-risk origins, complex chains, and repeated gaps merit deeper verification, while low-risk, well-documented chains need lighter but still recorded checks. Thirteen, what proves deforestation-free status. Satellite and plot analysis against the cut-off date plus chain integrity, assessed under current guidance, not a single certificate alone. Fourteen, can certificates replace due diligence. Certificates can support the file but do not replace your own collection, assessment, mitigation, and statement duties. Fifteen, what if harvest dates span the cut-off. Apply extra scrutiny, separate pre- and post-period volumes where possible, and seek counsel review. Sixteen, how do I train staff quickly. Use one pilot lot end to end, then repeat the same steps for the second lot with less supervision and log both.

Limitations. This kit provides process tools, not legal advice. It does not interpret the law for your facts, does not classify your goods definitively, does not validate coordinates or documents, does not assess satellite imagery, and does not submit statements on your behalf. It cannot compel suppliers to disclose data, cannot cure missing plots or permits, and cannot remove risk arising from mixing, incomplete chains, or outdated classifications. Regulatory texts, annexes, guidance, system fields, and enforcement practice may change. You must re-verify with official sources and qualified counsel. Never promise customers, management, or authorities a particular outcome. Use the Gap Memo to state plainly what remains unknown or unverified for each lot.

Disclosure and responsible use. The author of this kit has no access to your supply chain and makes no representation about your lots. Illustrative examples in this guide are simplified teaching scenarios, labeled illustrative, and do not describe any real company, farm, or shipment. Brief numbers such as deadline dates, plot counts in examples, and the \$69 kit price are stated for orientation only. Do not copy coordinates, permits, or statements between lots. Do not backdate reviews or signatures. Do not submit a statement you have not reviewed. If you discover an error after submission, correct it through

the proper official channel promptly and record the correction in the lot file. Keep this guide version 1.0 with the lot file so future reviewers know which procedure version you followed.

Implementation plan for a small team over eight weeks. Week 1, assign functions, list all Stock Keeping Units, and start the Scope Checker. Week 2, lock scope decisions, identify counsel questions, and draft supplier letters. Week 3, send letters, open the Supplier Register, and select one pilot lot. Week 4, chase coordinates and legality packs, log receipts daily, and test information-system access. Week 5, complete the risk assessment for the pilot lot, record mitigation, and hold an internal review. Week 6, correct gaps, run a second lot in parallel, and train staff on the file structure. Week 7, submit the pilot statement if the file supports it, file the Gap Memo, and update procedures. Week 8, review responsiveness by supplier, set quarterly re-verification dates, and brief management on residual risks and next steps.

Common errors and how to avoid them. Error one, treating catalog codes as declaration codes. Always copy codes from declarations. Error two, filing supplier emails without logging dates. Log every send and receipt in the register. Error three, accepting district names as plot data. Record them as partial and chase polygons or points. Error four, overwriting log rows after submission. Freeze submitted rows and use amendment rows. Error five, letting one person source, review, and approve the same lot. Separate duties in writing. Error six, assuming a certificate ends the work. File the certificate as one exhibit among several. Error seven, ignoring assortment changes. Re-run scope checks quarterly. Error eight, delaying letters until shipment week. Send letters at least six weeks before need, longer for new origins.

Appendix A glossary. Operator means the party first placing the product on the Union market or exporting it. Trader means a downstream party making it available. Placement means first making available on the Union market. Plot means the land unit where the commodity was produced, described by points or polygons as required. Due Diligence Statement means the electronic declaration submitted through the official system before placement. Risk assessment means the documented analysis of deforestation and legality risk for a lot. Mitigation means proportionate steps to address more-than-negligible risk. Gap Memo means the one-page lot closing note used in this kit. Illustrative means a simplified teaching scenario, not a real case or a prediction of outcomes.

Appendix B document retention index. Keep the Scope Checker with review dates, the Supplier Register with correspondence proofs, the DDS Preparation Log with frozen rows, coordinate files with format notes, legality documents with issuer and date, translations with preparer function, risk notes with reviewer sign-off, mitigation evidence, submitted statements with reference numbers, gap memos, training logs, system-access reviews, and customer or authority disclosure logs. Name files with lot identifier first, then document type, then date in year-month-day order. Store a read-only completed-lot snapshot separate from working drafts. Verify backups quarterly by restoring one lot file. Record the kit version used, which is 1.0, in each closed lot so later teams know the procedure baseline.

Appendix C how to brief counsel efficiently. Prepare a one-page brief per question with the product and code, the origin and supplier, the facts found, the documents held, the gap that remains, and the decision you propose. Attach the relevant log extract and the Gap Memo draft. Ask narrow questions such as whether a specific code maps to the annex, whether a specific document set supports a legality conclusion, or whether a specific mixed lot can support a statement. Record counsel answers with date and scope, and file them with the lot. Do not ask for blanket approvals across products or origins. Budget time for at least one round of follow-up questions, because first answers often require

additional facts you will need to request from suppliers.

Appendix D managing supplier relationships. Explain early why you request plots and permits, what format you need, and when you need it. Offer a short call to walk through the letter, especially for smallholders and cooperatives. Acknowledge receipt promptly and confirm what remains open so suppliers do not guess. Track responsiveness without blame, share a simple scorecard quarterly, and offer practical help such as a coordinate-collection checklist or a translation template. Where a supplier repeatedly cannot provide core data, reduce exposure gradually, qualify an alternative source, and document the commercial rationale separately from the regulatory file. Keep negotiations factual and written, and avoid pressuring suppliers to sign declarations they cannot support.

Appendix E information-system readiness. Request access early for the person who will submit statements and for one backup. Test login, lot creation, coordinate upload, document attachment, and reference-number retrieval in any available training or test area before live use. Map each workbook log field to the corresponding system field and note unit conversions. Prepare a submission checklist that mirrors Checklist D. Record who submitted what and when, and store system confirmations with the lot file. If roles change, update access the same week. Never share personal credentials, and review the access list quarterly. Where guidance updates change fields or formats, update your mapping note and re-test before the next live submission.

Appendix F scaling from pilot to routine. After two pilot lots, standardize the letter per commodity, pre-fill recurring supplier data in the register, and set service-level expectations such as coordinates within fifteen working days. Create a weekly evidence-review slot, a monthly supplier-responsiveness review, and a quarterly scope and classification re-verification. Add new origins through the same pilot path, never directly into high-volume placement. Track cycle time from letter to submission per lot and investigate outliers. Keep a lessons log with one line per lot, what slowed the file, and what you changed. This steady routine matters more than any single tool, because consistent files across lots demonstrate a working system rather than a one-time effort.

Final review and sign-off. Before first live placement, confirm that scope decisions are locked and reviewed, that the register covers all direct suppliers, that the pilot file contains real coordinates and legality documents, that risk notes are signed, that the statement mapping is tested, that the deadline calendar has owners and dates, and that open gaps are either closed or reviewed by counsel with written notes. Record this review in a short sign-off sheet with date and functions. Schedule the next review after the first three live lots, then quarterly. Keep this guide, the workbook version, and the template versions together with the sign-off so the basis of your process is traceable. Remember the standing caveat: re-verify scope and classifications with official sources and counsel, because this area continues to evolve. This guide is not legal advice and promises no outcome.

Deep dive 1 reading customs codes without errors. Pull codes from filed declarations and freight documents, not from marketing sheets. Compare each code character by character to the annex entries, because one digit can change the mapping. Where a finished product contains multiple components, assess each component separately and record the analysis per component. Where packaging and product share a declaration, separate the goods classification from the packaging treatment under current guidance. Keep a code-history note per Stock Keeping Unit showing prior codes, change dates, and reasons, so re-verification is quick. When in doubt, mark the row uncertain and route it to counsel with the declaration extract attached, rather than forcing a premature in-scope or out-of-scope label that later proves wrong.

Deep dive 2 collecting polygons that survive review. Ask for files in a stated open format with the coordinate reference system identified. Check that each polygon closes, that vertex counts meet the minimum where the rules set one, that points fall inside the declared country and sub-national area, and that harvest dates align with the lot period. Count plots and points and compare them to the supplier cover note. Where a cooperative aggregates smallholders, require a table linking each plot identifier to a farmer code, a harvest date, and a polygon or point reference. Store the original file untouched plus a working copy for checks. Log validation steps with date and reviewer function. Where files fail validation, return them the same day with a clear correction list instead of editing supplier data yourself.

Deep dive 3 legality packs per commodity. For wood, expect harvest permits, transport documents, forest-management evidence, and chain-of-custody records linking stump to shipment. For coffee and cocoa, expect farm tenure or collection agreements, cooperative purchase records, environmental licences where required, and export permits. For soy, expect land-use documentation, production-area declarations, transport and storage records, and crush-plant intake logs. For palm, expect mill supply-base lists, concession or tenure evidence, environmental and labor records, and refinery traceability statements. For rubber, expect smallholder purchase ledgers, processing records, and transport notes. For cattle, expect holding registrations, movement records, and slaughter and processing links. Adapt the list per origin with counsel, because document names and issuers vary by country.

Deep dive 4 assessing risk on paper before visiting the field. Review origin-area signals from official classifications and reputable public sources, chain length and number of intermediaries, prior audit or grievance history, document consistency across permits and volumes, and timeliness of supplier responses. Cross-check quantities from farm to shipment for plausibility, compare harvest periods to seasonal calendars, and flag round numbers or repeated identical coordinates as data-quality concerns to be resolved, not ignored. Write the risk note in plain sentences that cite exhibits by file name. Conclude with negligible or non-negligible in the sense used by the official framework, describe the reasoning, and list mitigation where needed. Have a second function review any non-negligible conclusion before mitigation starts.

Deep dive 5 mitigation that actually helps. Useful mitigation includes obtaining missing polygons, replacing unverifiable plots, adding independent field checks, tightening segregation at a named node, switching a high-risk collection point, splitting a mixed lot into verifiable and non-verifiable streams, or pausing placement until evidence arrives. Weak mitigation includes repeated email reminders without deadlines, accepting summary assurances without exhibits, or adding generic certificates that do not address the specific gap. Record each mitigation action with owner, due date, evidence received, and effect on the risk conclusion. If mitigation does not reduce risk to negligible under the official standard, do not place the lot. Record the no-placement decision with the same care as a placement, because it shows the system works.

Deep dive 6 handling micro and small enterprise realities. Smaller importers often buy through agents, share containers, and lack dedicated regulatory staff. Assign the four functions across existing roles in writing, even if two functions sit with one person plus a documented second reviewer from outside the purchase decision. Use the same sheets but fewer rows, and keep correspondence templates ready so outreach does not depend on drafting from scratch. Pool coordinate validation with a peer or service provider where appropriate, but keep responsibility for the statement with the operator. Use the 30

June 2027 date as a readiness deadline, not a start date, and run at least one pilot lot months earlier so lessons arrive while there is still time to adjust suppliers and procedures.

Deep dive 7 working with cooperatives and smallholders. Cooperatives aggregate many small plots and often hold the only practical path to farm-level data. Agree a simple data standard: farmer code, plot identifier, point or polygon reference, harvest date, and volume delivered. Provide a one-page collection sheet and a worked illustrative example marked illustrative so field staff see the expected format. Plan collection around harvest when farmers are reachable. Pay for the extra administrative work explicitly rather than expecting it for free, and record the arrangement. Verify a sample of plots independently, resolve duplicates and shared-plot cases in writing, and keep the farmer-code key secure with limited access. Thank contributors by confirming receipt and closing the loop on corrections.

Deep dive 8 customs and customer documentation. Align commercial invoices, packing lists, customs declarations, and the Due Diligence Statement on product description, quantity, units, origin, and reference numbers. Differences across documents invite questions and delay clearance. Provide customers with the statement reference, the lot identifier, and a contact function for file queries, without disclosing farm-personal data beyond what the rules and privacy law allow. Keep a disclosure log. Where customers request additional assurances beyond the official statement, respond with file-based facts and the Gap Memo summary, not with broad promises. Review incoterms and responsibility splits per lot so the operator identity is clear to every party before shipment.

Deep dive 9 monitoring change after go-live. Assign one person to watch official journals, guidance pages, classification updates, and system notices on a fixed weekly slot. Log each update with date, source title, and effect on scope, evidence, or submission steps. Trigger re-verification of affected lots before submission, not after. Review supplier responsiveness monthly, scope quarterly, system mapping after each guidance update, and training after each procedure change. Keep a change log at the front of the procedure file. This routine operationalizes the regulatory-change caveat so it is not just a paragraph but a lived control. When in doubt about the effect of an update, pause affected submissions and seek counsel review on the specific facts rather than interpreting novel points alone.

Deep dive 10 preparing for checks and audits. Authorities and customers may ask for the lot file, the statement reference, and proof of the process. Produce the frozen log row, the coordinate file reference, the legality exhibits, the risk note, mitigation records, the approval, the submission confirmation, and the gap memo as one set. Answer factual questions with exhibit citations and dates. Do not speculate about missing items; refer to the Gap Memo. Record every external request and response. After each check, hold a short lessons review and update the procedure, the letter, or the sheets so the same question is easier to answer next time. This closes the loop between daily operational discipline and external scrutiny without promising any particular audit outcome.

Closing note on scope, counsel, and care. This kit gives you a practical starting structure for a demanding rule. It does not replace reading the current official text, following current official guidance, or seeking qualified counsel for your products, origins, and lots. Re-verify scope and classifications before each consequential decision, keep files that show your reasoning, and treat every gap as an instruction to act, not as paperwork to hide. The discipline of complete logs, honest memos, and timely supplier outreach will serve you whether you place ten lots a year or one thousand. Version 1.0 ends here. Record the version you used with each lot, and review for updates before expanding to new commodities or origins. General information only, not legal advice, and no outcome is promised.